
INTERNATIONAL A-LEVEL ENGLISH LITERATURE

UNIT 4A LITERARY REPRESENTATIONS

Thursday 15 June 2023 07:00 GMT Time allowed: 2 hours 30 minutes

Materials

For this paper you must have:

- an Oxford International AQA Examinations 12-page answer book.

Instructions

- Use black ink or black ball-point pen.
- Write the information required on the front of your answer book.
- Do all rough work in your answer book. Cross through any work you do not want to be marked.
- You must answer **all** questions. There is **one** question in Section A and **one** question in Section B.

Information

- The maximum mark for this paper is 50.
- The marks for questions are shown in brackets.
- You will be marked on your ability to:
 - use good English
 - organise information clearly
 - analyse carefully the writers' methods
 - use specialist vocabulary where appropriate.

Section A: Prose

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Read the following extract carefully. It is taken from *The Garden of Evening Mists*, a novel by the Malaysian writer Tan Twan Eng, first published in 2012. The novel is set in Malaya during the years following World War II. The narrator is searching for clues to the fate of her sister with whom she was imprisoned in a prisoner of war camp.

Write an analysis of this extract, in which you focus on the significance of the representation of the suffering caused by war.

[25 marks]

I looked around the passageway; I had to find out more about what he knew. I had to. It was the only scrap of information I had come across after all this time.

‘If I write a letter to my son,’ he said, ‘will you post it to him for me? Intact. Not censored?’

‘If I’m satisfied that what you tell me is true.’

‘They were only rumours,’ he repeated, as though worried that he had promised too much. I stared at him. ‘*Kin no yuri*,’ he said, and then translated it for me even though I understood what it meant. ‘Golden Lily.’

‘That tells me nothing,’ I said, raising my voice. From the other end of the corridor the Sikh guard looked at me. I signalled that everything was fine.

‘It is the name given to the kind of place you were sent to,’ Hideyoshi said. ‘You would know more about it than me if you had been taken there.’

It was all he knew, I realised; all he could tell me. The sense of hope that had fired me up a short while before, the hope that someone else knew of the camp I had been sent to, disappeared. I backed away from the bars.

‘You are not going to keep to our agreement,’ he said, ‘are you?’

I spun around and walked away from him. I returned to his cell half an hour later. He opened his eyes and looked up when I called his name. I passed him some writing materials between the bars and went to lean against the wall, watching him write. A short while later he came to the bars and handed me a letter sealed inside a light blue envelope. He looked at my hand, the hand with the missing fingers. ‘You should forget all that’s happened to you,’ he said.

The address on the envelope was written in English and Japanese. ‘How old is your son?’

‘Eleven. Eiji was three, almost four when I last saw him. He will not remember me.’ I weighed the envelope on my palm. ‘I thought it would be heavier.’

‘How much paper do you need to tell your son you love him?’ he replied.

Staring at him, this man who had ordered an entire village to be killed, I felt a profound sadness for him, for us.

When the guards came to take Hideyoshi, he asked me to walk with him. I hesitated, then I nodded. Walking along the passageway, we passed the other prisoners in their cells. A few of them stood to attention, saluting him from behind the bars. Hideyoshi kept his eyes straight ahead, his lips moving soundlessly.

The sky was streaked with the carnage of sunset when we came out to the yard at the back of the prison. Hideyoshi stopped and turned his face upwards, breathing in the light from the first stars of the evening. The guards pushed him up a flight of steps to the hanging platform and positioned him beneath the noose. They looped the rope around his neck and tightened it. He stumbled, but regained his balance. One of the guards held up a blindfold. Hideyoshi shook his head.

A Buddhist monk, appointed to conduct the rites for these executions, began to pray, thumbing the string of beads twined around his fingers as line after line of prayers unreeled from his throat. The droning washed over me. Hideyoshi and I looked at one another until the trapdoor cracked open and he dropped into an abyss only he could see.

Glossary:

Sikh: someone holding Sikh religious beliefs

Buddhist: person who practises Buddhism

Turn over for Section B

Section B: Poetry

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Read carefully the following poem, 'To the Foot from its Child', by the Chilean poet Pablo Neruda, published in 1972.

Write an analysis of this poem, in which you focus on the significance of the representation of childhood and ageing.

[25 marks]

To the Foot from its Child

The child's foot is not yet aware it's a foot,
and would like to be a butterfly or an apple.

But in time, stones and bits of glass,
streets, ladders,
and the paths in the rough earth
go on teaching the foot that it cannot fly,
cannot be a fruit bulging on the branch.
Then, the child's foot
is defeated, falls
in the battle,
is a prisoner
condemned to live in a shoe.

Bit by bit, in that dark,
it grows to know the world in its own way,
out of touch with its fellow, enclosed,
feeling out life like a blind man.

These soft nails
of quartz, bunched together,
grow hard, and change themselves
into opaque substance, hard as horn,
and the tiny, petalled toes of the child
grow bunched and out of trim,
take on the form of eyeless reptiles
with triangular heads, like worms.
Later, they grow calloused
and are covered
with the faint volcanoes of death,
a coarsening hard to accept.

But this blind thing walks
without respite, never stopping
for hour after hour,
the one foot, the other,
now the man's,
now the woman's,
up above,
down below,
through fields, mines,
markets and ministries,
backwards,
far afield, inward,
forward,

this foot toils in its shoe,
scarcely taking time
to bare itself in love or sleep;
it walks, they walk,
until the whole man chooses to stop.

And then it descended
underground, unaware,
for there, everything, everything was dark.
It never knew it had ceased to be a foot
or if they were burying it so that it could fly
or so that it could become
an apple.

Pablo Neruda

Glossary:

quartz: a largely colourless mineral

calloused: hardened (skin)

END OF QUESTIONS

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